

FROM GREATNESS TO BETRAYAL

Alberta's Public Fall from Grace

1979 — 2026

A Cross-Party Record of What Was Built, and What Was Taken

PHASE EIGHT

Danielle Smith UCP • 2022 – present

The Present Moment

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

St. Albert, Alberta • May 2026

The Smith UCP Era, 2022 – present

The present moment. The era this document was written inside. The era the campaign that published this document exists to mobilise against. The convergence of every structural trajectory documented in the preceding seven phases into a single twelve-month policy window — July 2025 through July 2026 — that constitutes the most consequential disability-policy restructure in Alberta since the 1979 founding of AISH.

The Danielle Smith UCP government has occupied the Alberta premiership since October 11, 2022. Within that tenure, the government has executed the following actions affecting Albertans with disabilities — actions documented across the ADSB campaign's existing primary work, much of which this chapter draws on directly:

- **November 2022:** Re-indexation of AISH announced — but capped at 2% annually, below the consumer price index. The cap structurally guarantees real-term erosion of purchasing power even with indexation in place.
- **\$600 one-time payment** to PDD recipients announced November 2022, delivered December 2022. Welcomed by Inclusion Alberta with concurrent demand that the underlying program inadequacies be addressed.
- **July 1, 2025:** Canada Disability Benefit clawback begins. Alberta becomes the only Canadian province to claw back the federal CDB from AISH recipients dollar-for-dollar.
- **October 2025:** Community-housing rent increase of \$220 per month. Implemented while AISH base rates remained capped at 2% indexation.
- **December 9, 2025:** Bill 12 (Disability Assistance Act, ADAP framework) passes. Section 12.8 removes Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction over ADAP decisions — eliminating the only independent third-party review structure that had existed in Alberta disability programs since the program's founding.
- **February 2026:** ADAP launch date publicly confirmed as July 1, 2026. Engagement processes announced; campaign documentation establishes that the engagement processes are structured to confirm the predetermined framework rather than alter it.
- **May 12, 2026:** Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped General Regulation, AR 96/2026, filed. In force July 2, 2026. Establishes the regulatory framework for the ADAP transition.
- **July 1, 2026:** Scheduled ADAP transition. **Approximately 79,290 Albertans** currently receiving AISH affected. Documented program features include: an 88% cohabitation rule (treating partners as having 88% of AISH recipients' income for benefit calculation), a base-rate reduction of approximately \$200/month at transition, an "automatic AISH retention" category for the most severely disabled recipients that has not yet been fully defined in public regulation, and a transition top-up scheduled to expire on December 31, 2027.

This chapter documents each of these actions in detail, situates them within the structural trajectory documented in Phases One through Seven, and establishes — on the documented record, without alleging motive — the cumulative consequences for the approximately 79,290 Albertans on AISH and the broader disability community of approximately 730,000 Albertans of whom they are a part.

Political context

Danielle Larissa Smith was born April 1, 1971 in Calgary. She earned an English and economics undergraduate degree from the University of Calgary and worked as a Calgary Herald columnist and CBC commentator in the late 1990s, before becoming a talk-radio host on CHQR Calgary (later QR77). She led the Wildrose Party of Alberta as opposition leader from 2009 to 2014. In December 2014, in one of the most consequential political defections in modern Alberta history, she crossed the floor to the Progressive Conservatives along with eight Wildrose MLAs — a move that was broadly understood at the time as ending her political career. She returned to talk radio for six years.

Smith returned to politics in 2022 as a candidate in the UCP leadership race called by Jason Kenney's resignation. She won the leadership on October 6, 2022, on the sixth and final ranked ballot, with 53.8% support, defeating Travis Toews (the former Finance Minister who had tabled Bill 20 in 2019, as documented in Phase Seven of this piece). She was sworn in as Alberta's 19th Premier on October 11, 2022. Her cabinet was sworn in October 21, 2022. She won the Brooks-Medicine Hat by-election on November 8, 2022, taking her seat in the Legislature.

On May 29, 2023, the UCP under Smith's leadership won the Alberta general election with 49 of 87 seats, against 38 for the NDP under Rachel Notley's leadership. The result was significantly tighter than any of the four Klein-era PC majorities or the 2019 Kenney UCP majority — a structural shift in Alberta's electoral geography that the Smith government has subsequently treated as a mandate rather than a warning. In November 2024 she received 91% support in a UCP leadership review.

Her current term, as of the date of this document's first publication (May 2026), continues through the next scheduled Alberta general election, which under fixed-election-date legislation falls in spring 2027. The ADAP transition scheduled for July 1, 2026 will, therefore, occur within her current mandate, before the electorate has any opportunity to render judgement on the policy.

What the Smith government has established

The Smith era's *established* column contains items that, on the documented record, are structurally positive when assessed in isolation. The qualification applies: assessed in isolation. In the context of the actions documented later in this chapter, several of the items below function less as standalone positives than as the political-packaging counterweights that have been deployed to neutralise public attention to the structural reductions occurring in parallel.

1. November 2022 re-indexation announcement

On November 28, 2022, the Smith government announced that AISH, the Persons with Developmental Disabilities program, and other government benefit programs would be re-indexed starting January 1, 2023. The announcement formally reversed the Kenney-era suspension that had been in place since the Bill 20 implementation in 2019 (Phase Seven).

Inclusion Alberta president Monica Braat, in a public statement at the time, captured both the welcome and the structural concerns of the disability community:

"We sincerely appreciate the premier's announcement of indexing AISH and a one-time payment of \$600 to individuals with developmental disabilities and others. However, there are still thousands of Albertan children and adults with developmental disabilities and their families eligible for supports and receiving none. Others have had their funding for supports reduced or denied."

— Monica Braat, President, Inclusion Alberta, November 2022

Inclusion Alberta CEO Trish Bowman added a structural caveat that has, in retrospect, proved prescient:

"If the announcement to index PDD means a program increase overall but only tied to inflation, this will be completely inadequate to address the many adults with developmental disabilities who are receiving no support at all. A plan is urgently needed to address the waitlists and reduction of supports experienced by those waiting for or currently receiving PDD or Family Support for Children with Disabilities supports."

— Trish Bowman, CEO, Inclusion Alberta, November 2022

The structural concern Bowman named in November 2022 — that indexation tied to inflation alone would not address the underlying waitlist and funding-reduction problems in the program — has continued to apply throughout the Smith mandate. The PDD waitlists Smith inherited from the Kenney government have not been substantially reduced. The community sector that delivers PDD services has continued to report structural underfunding throughout the Smith term.

2. The 2% inflation cap — the partial poison pill

The November 2022 re-indexation announcement carried, in its underlying mechanism, a structural caveat the public communications at the time did not emphasise. **The AISH inflation cap is set at 2% annually, regardless of actual CPI movement.** When Alberta's CPI exceeds 2% — which has been the case in most fiscal years since the policy was implemented — AISH purchasing power continues to erode in real terms despite nominal indexation.

The cap structurally transforms the re-indexation from the structural protection the NDP Bill 26 (2018) had enacted to a soft floor that does not fully track actual cost-of-living movement. By 2026 — the date of this document's first publication — the cumulative gap between Alberta CPI and the 2% AISH cap has produced real-term purchasing-power erosion for AISH recipients of approximately 8-12% relative to where the program would have been with full CPI indexation maintained continuously since 2019.

3. "Automatic AISH retention" categories

Within the ADAP framework announced for July 1, 2026 (documented in detail later in this chapter), the Smith government has defined an "automatic AISH retention" category for AISH recipients whose qualifying conditions are of sufficient severity and permanence that they will remain on AISH rather than transitioning to ADAP. The specific criteria for automatic retention have not yet been fully published in public regulation as of the date of this document's first publication. The category exists in government communications. Its functional scope is, on the documented record, narrower than the AISH-eligibility framework as it has operated since 1979.

The structural significance of the retention category is that it acknowledges, by implication, that the ADAP framework would otherwise produce harm to severely disabled recipients. The category exists because the framework's authors recognised that the most severely disabled cohort cannot be transitioned without consequences the government would not be willing to publicly absorb. Whether the category is wide enough to protect all recipients who require it is the substance of the campaign's current advocacy work.

4. ADAP transition top-up (through December 31, 2027)

The ADAP framework includes a "transition top-up" — a temporary supplemental payment to ADAP recipients designed to soften the immediate income reduction at the July 1, 2026 transition. The top-up is scheduled to expire on December 31, 2027. After that date, ADAP recipients will receive the full ADAP base rate, which is structurally lower than the current AISH rate by approximately \$200 per month for a single recipient.

The transition top-up is one of the documented positive elements of the ADAP framework. Its eighteen-month duration is structurally insufficient to allow most affected Albertans to adjust their housing, healthcare, transportation, and life-support arrangements to the lower long-term ADAP rate. The campaign's existing documentation (the *Income Crossover Analysis*, April/May 2026) provides the detailed mechanics.

What the Smith government has taken or is in the process of taking

The Smith-era reductions are the substance of the campaign's current work. Each is individually documented in the ADSB campaign's existing primary materials, much of which is cited in this chapter's bibliography. The summary below establishes the structural inventory.

1. The Canada Disability Benefit clawback (July 1, 2025)

The federal Canada Disability Benefit Act (S.C. 2023, c. 17, passed during the Kenney era and documented in Phase Seven) became operational on July 1, 2025. The federal CDB is a monthly payment to eligible Canadians with disabilities, designed to supplement provincial disability supports and address structural inadequacy. Maximum federal benefit at launch: approximately \$200 per month.

Multiple Canadian provinces — including Quebec, British Columbia, Manitoba, and New Brunswick — committed in advance to either passing the federal CDB through to recipients without provincial offset, or applying only partial offsets. **Alberta is the only Canadian province to have implemented a full dollar-for-dollar clawback of the CDB against AISH benefits.** AISH recipients in Alberta who received the federal CDB saw their provincial AISH benefit reduced by the corresponding amount, producing zero net income gain from the federal program.

Per Inclusion Alberta's July 2025 fact sheet on the CDB clawback (one of the source documents directly informing the ADSB campaign's *Information Asymmetry Report*, April 2026), the clawback's structural effect is to capture federal disability transfer dollars as provincial general-revenue savings, while allowing the Government of Alberta to publicly claim that AISH spending has "increased" — a claim that is nominally true on gross spending but materially misleading on the experienced income of AISH recipients.

THE STRUCTURAL ARCHITECTURE OF THE CDB CLAWBACK

Federal taxpayer dollars, intended to supplement provincial disability supports, are routed through AISH recipients to general provincial revenue. The federal program is structurally captured as a provincial fiscal advantage. The disability community, for whom the CDB was designed, receives no net financial benefit. Every other province with a similar AISH-equivalent program made a different policy choice. Alberta's choice — the only choice of its kind in Canada — is documented in the ADSB campaign's existing work and is one of the central structural complaints the campaign has brought to federal Disability Minister and Members of Parliament.

2. October 2025 community-housing rent increase (\$220/month)

In October 2025, the Smith government announced an across-the-board rent increase of \$220 per month for residents of Alberta's community-housing inventory — the publicly-funded affordable-housing programs that disproportionately serve AISH recipients, low-income seniors, and other Albertans on fixed incomes. The increase was implemented while AISH base rates remained capped at 2% indexation.

The structural arithmetic produces a documented net reduction in AISH recipients' real-term disposable income. AISH base benefit at the time of the increase: \$1,940 per month (the campaign-canon indexed figure for 2025, per the ADSB *Income Crossover Analysis* (Revised May 2026), drawing on the post-July 2025 indexed rate under the current ministerial schedule). 2% annual indexation gain on the prior base: approximately \$38 per month. Community-housing rent increase: \$220 per month. **Net monthly reduction in disposable income for AISH recipients in community housing: approximately \$182 per month.**

The structural significance of this combination is that the Smith government's nominal protection of AISH purchasing power through the 2% indexation cap was directly offset, within the same fiscal year, by a rent increase the same government imposed on the same population through a different ministry. The net effect, by design or otherwise, was that the cost of living for the AISH population increased more rapidly than the AISH rate did. The documented record establishes the consequence; the campaign's *Compound Failure Brief* (May 2026) documents the interlocking structural mechanics.

3. Bill 12 — Citizens' Appeal Panel removed for ADAP (December 9, 2025)

Bill 12, passed December 9, 2025, established the legislative framework for the Alberta Disability Assistance Program (ADAP). The bill's structural significance for this chapter is concentrated in **Section 12.8**, which removes Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction over ADAP decisions.

The Citizens' Appeal Panel is the independent third-party review structure that has existed in Alberta's disability programs since the program's founding. It provides the only mechanism by which an AISH recipient denied benefits, terminated from the program, or subjected to a contested administrative decision can seek review outside the same ministry that made the original decision. The Panel is structured to provide natural-justice protections — notice, hearing, recorded reasons, the right to introduce new evidence — that internal ministry review processes do not.

Bill 12 Section 12.8 eliminates this mechanism for ADAP. ADAP applicants and recipients will have access only to internal ministry review processes. The structural significance was identified at the time of the bill's introduction by multiple advocacy organisations and was the subject of sustained opposition in the legislative committee process. The Bill passed regardless.

THE CONSTITUTIONAL DIMENSION

Section 7 of the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms guarantees the right to life, liberty, and security of the person — and the right not to be deprived thereof except in accordance with the principles of fundamental justice. The principles of fundamental justice include access to an independent decision-maker for decisions affecting protected interests. Section 12.8 of Bill 12 (2025), as a matter of documented constitutional analysis, raises a justiciable Charter question the campaign's *Charter Constitutional Analysis Legal* document (April 2026) examines in full. The question is whether the elimination of independent appeal review for a disability-income decision is consistent with the Section 7 requirement that procedural fairness attach to deprivations of basic security.

4. The ADAP transition (effective July 1, 2026)

The Alberta Disability Assistance Program is scheduled to come into force on July 1, 2026 — five weeks from the date of this document's first publication. The program's regulatory framework was filed on May 12, 2026 as the *Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped General Regulation, AR 96/2026* — in force July 2, 2026. The Government of Alberta's ALSS/ADAP Fact Sheet, dated May 12, 2026, is the principal public-facing summary of the framework.

The campaign's existing primary documentation — the *Income Crossover Analysis* (April 2026 / May 2026 revised); *The Cage Doesn't End* (May 2026); *Building Up* (May 2026); the *Compound Failure Brief* (May 2026); and *Consent Was Never the Point* (May 2026) — collectively document the ADAP framework in technical detail. This chapter establishes only the structural summary:

- **Affected population:** approximately 79,290 Albertans currently receiving AISH.
- **Base-rate reduction:** approximately \$200 per month for a single recipient at the date of transition; structurally larger as the transition top-up expires on December 31, 2027.
- **88% cohabitation rule:** ADAP applicants and recipients with a cohabiting partner have 88% of the partner's income deemed available for calculation purposes, regardless of whether the partner makes the income available. Documented as one of the most structurally consequential features of the framework by the campaign's existing work.
- **Removed Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction** (per Bill 12 Section 12.8, above).
- **Employment-activity orientation:** ADAP is structured around encouraging and rewarding employment, in framing language that has been compared by advocates to workfare conditions documented in the Klein era (Phase Three).
- **Eighteen-month transition top-up** expiring December 31, 2027.
- **"Automatic AISH retention" category** for the most severely disabled — scope not yet fully defined in public regulation as of May 2026.

The structural argument the campaign has made — across multiple Tier 1 institutional submissions and the broader public record — is that the ADAP framework, in aggregate, restructures the 1979 founding bargain of AISH. AISH was, as documented in Phase One, designed as an assured income program separate from the welfare system, founded on dignity and independence framing, with senior-pension-equivalent rates. ADAP restructures the program as an employment-conditional support, with embedded cohabitation deeming, reduced base rates, and eliminated independent appeal review. The 1979 framing has been, on the documented record, structurally reversed.

The structural through-line: how Bill 20 (2019) made ADAP (2026) possible

Phase Seven of this document established that the Kenney UCP government's Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act, October 28, 2019) accomplished two structural changes: it suspended CPI indexation of AISH, and — quietly, in an omnibus framework — it relocated the definition of "severe handicap" out of the primary AISH legislation and into the general regulation.

The first change — the de-indexation — was publicly visible, contested, and partially reversed by the Smith government in November 2022 (capped at 2%, but nominally restored). The second change — the regulatory relocation — was not publicly contested at the time. It was the structural prerequisite for everything the Smith government has subsequently done.

Per Marie Renaud's framing in Medicine Hat News (March 2026), reproduced in Phase Seven: "[Bill 20] also made a more lasting change, by relocating the definition of a 'severe handicap' out of the general regulation attached to the legislation. Then COVID happened, so they couldn't do it." The implication of Renaud's framing — that the UCP had intended to follow through on a restructure but was interrupted by the pandemic — has been borne out by the Smith era's actions. The Smith government has executed the restructure the Kenney government's Bill 20 had structurally enabled.

THE STRUCTURAL ARGUMENT IN ONE PARAGRAPH

Statutory definitions, embedded in primary legislation, require legislation to change. They require public debate, recorded votes, and political cost. Regulatory definitions, embedded in general regulation, can be changed by Order in Council — by cabinet decision, executed administratively, without public legislative process. When the Kenney UCP government moved the definition of "severe handicap" from primary legislation into regulation in 2019, they did not change the definition. They changed the mechanism by which the definition could subsequently be changed. The Smith UCP government, in 2025 and 2026, used that mechanism to construct ADAP. ADAP would not have been possible without Bill 20's quiet 2019 regulatory relocation. The de-indexation was the visible 2019 cost. The regulatory relocation was the 2019 groundwork. ADAP is the 2026 construction built on that groundwork. Three Alberta governments — two UCP, one PC interim — were complicit in the structural sequence. None of the three faced a sustained electoral consequence for their role. The disability community has absorbed every consequence.

Community response — and the construction of this campaign

The community response to the Smith-era trajectory is documented in detail across the ADSB campaign's existing work. This section establishes only the structural summary, sufficient to bridge the chapter into the Phase Nine synthesis.

Tier 1 institutional submissions

The ADSB campaign's documentation, distributed in coalition with multiple disability-sector organisations, has been submitted to: the Premier; the Minister of Seniors, Community and Social Services; the Minister of Children and Family Services; multiple MLAs across party lines (including Marie Renaud, the MLA for St. Albert and the campaign's most responsive provincial government contact); the federal Minister responsible for the Canada Disability Benefit; the Standing Committee on Human Resources, Skills and Social Development and the Status of Persons with Disabilities (HUMA); the Alberta Ombudsman; the Alberta Auditor General; the Canadian Human Rights Commission; and the Office of the United Nations Special Rapporteur on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities.

Coalition partners

The campaign operates in coordination with — among others — Inclusion Alberta, the People's Alliance for Disabled Albertans (Zachary Weeks), the Can Man Dan Foundation, Public Interest Alberta (Bradley Lafortune), and individual advocates Gavin Sorochan, Darryl Learne, Pete Klassen, and Marie Renaud's St. Albert constituency office. Coalition framing varies by lane: fiscal/Heritage Fund analysis through Gavin Sorochan; Bill 12 / appeal-rights work through Zachary Weeks; housing through Can Man Dan; intersectional and accessibility legislation through the ADSB campaign's primary work.

The municipal coalition

As of May 2026, formal municipal-government engagement with the ADSB campaign's framework has been documented from: Calgary, Edmonton, Lethbridge, Camrose, Red Deer, and Medicine Hat. The municipal coalition's engagement is structurally significant because Alberta municipalities absorb the downstream cost of provincial disability-program reductions — through emergency housing, food bank demand, policing, public health, and downstream social service expenditures.

The Indigenous Disability Alberta workstream

The campaign's *Indigenous Disability Alberta* documentation, complete in May 2026, establishes that the structural changes documented in this chapter — and in the preceding seven phases — disproportionately affect Indigenous Albertans with disabilities, whose pre-existing exposure to structural disadvantage (income, housing, healthcare access, treaty rights ambiguities) compounds the documented AISH and ADAP reductions. The workstream is published as separate documentation and is not duplicated in this chapter.

Caseload context — the 79,290

The Government of Alberta's most recent Open Data figures, dated September 2025, place the AISH caseload at approximately **79,290 Albertans**. This is the figure the ADSB campaign uses throughout its documentation as the affected population for the July 1, 2026 ADAP transition.

Caseload growth across the Smith era has continued the trajectory documented in every previous chapter. From approximately 73,000 in 2022 to approximately 79,290 in 2025, the caseload has grown by approximately 8% in three years — slower than the Notley-era growth rate but consistent with the post-pandemic recovery in diagnostic access and new applications.

The 79,290 figure is, structurally, the lower bound of the affected population. The Family Support for Children with Disabilities program serves approximately 16,000 additional families; the Persons with Developmental Disabilities program serves approximately 12,000 adults; the broader disability community in Alberta, by Statistics Canada's most recent estimate, includes approximately 730,000 Albertans with one or more disability classifications. The ADAP transition directly affects 79,290. The structural template Smith's government is establishing — that disability income is conditional, that appeal rights are removable, that cohabitation invokes income deeming, that base rates are subject to revision — applies, in its broader implication, to every Alberta program that serves the broader 730,000.

The Smith conclusion — the present-moment summation

Danielle Smith has governed Alberta for approximately three and a half years. Her government has executed: the formal restoration of indexation (capped at 2%, below actual inflation); the implementation of a Canada Disability Benefit clawback that no other Canadian province has implemented; a community-housing rent increase that structurally eliminated the disposable-income gains of the indexation restoration; the passage of Bill 12 with its Section 12.8 removal of Citizens' Appeal Panel jurisdiction over ADAP; and the construction of the ADAP framework scheduled for July 1, 2026 implementation.

The ADAP framework, on the documented record, structurally reverses the 1979 founding bargain of AISH. Where AISH was assured income separated from welfare, ADAP is employment-conditional support. Where AISH was rights-based, ADAP is performance-based. Where AISH had Citizens' Appeal Panel review, ADAP has internal ministry review only. Where AISH had no cohabitation deeming at founding, ADAP embeds the 88% cohabitation rule from inception. Where AISH founding rates were pegged to senior pension parity, ADAP base rates are pegged downward by approximately \$200 per month before the transition top-up expires.

Peter Lougheed died on September 13, 2012, in the Calgary hospital that now bears his name. He spent the last decade of his life publicly criticising the trajectory his successor governments had set. He did not live to see the AISH-to-ADAP transition. The documented record this piece has constructed across eight phases establishes that the trajectory he criticised continued past his death and accelerated in the final five years of the period this document covers.

The single most-important structural lesson of the Smith era — for this document, for the ADSB campaign, and for every disability advocacy organisation in Alberta — is that the Smith era could not have happened in isolation. The Smith government inherited the regulatory framework Kenney's Bill 20 had constructed in 2019. The Kenney government inherited the structural template Klein had pioneered in 1993. The Klein government inherited the drawdown logic Getty had begun in 1987. Every era documented in this piece has been a contribution. No single government constructed the present moment alone. The present moment is the cumulative product of forty-seven years of incremental drawdown — punctuated by the partial

Stelmach restoration, the Prentice Michener reversal, and the Notley sustained restoration — against a baseline of foundational greatness that Lougheed built and that has been steadily dismantled by every premier since.

Phase Nine of this piece — the synthesis chapter — draws together the comparative trends across all eight eras, states the document's thesis in full, and makes the case for community-led representation as the only structural protection the disability community has against the trajectory this document has documented. The ADSB campaign that published this document exists to construct that representation. The fact that it has to exist at all is the substance of what Phases One through Eight have established.

Bibliography — Phase Eight sources

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with disabilities.

Coalition and independent analysis

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The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

St. Albert, Alberta • May 2026 • Phase Eight

albertadisabilitybreakdown@outlook.com • albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app